

Task analysis

- Task descriptions are often used to envision new systems or devices
- Task analysis is used mainly to investigate an existing situation, not to envision new products.
- It is important not to focus on superficial activities
 - What are people trying to achieve?
 - Why are they trying to achieve it?
 - How are they going about it?
- Many techniques, the most popular is Hierarchical Task Analysis (HTA)

Hierarchical Task Analysis

- Involves breaking a task down into subtasks, then sub-sub-tasks and so on. These are grouped as plans which specify how the tasks might be performed in practice
- HTA focuses on physical and observable actions, and includes looking at actions not related to software or an interaction device
- Start with a user goal which is examined and the main tasks for achieving it are identified
- Tasks are sub-divided into sub-tasks

Example Hierarchical Task Analysis

0. In order to buy a DVD

1. locate DVD

2. add DVD to shopping basket

3. enter payment details

4. complete address

5. confirm order

plan 0: If regular user do 1-2-5.

 If new user do 1-2-3-4-5.

Example Hierarchical Task Analysis (graphical)

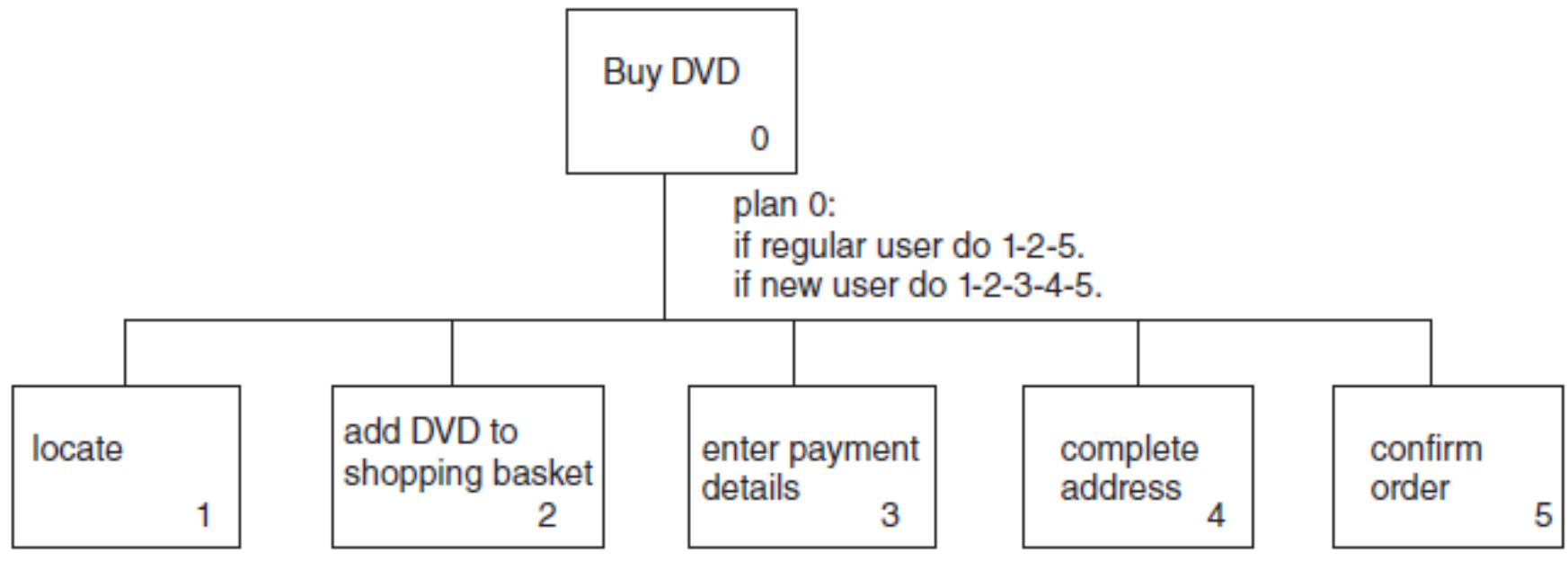


Figure 10.15 A graphical representation of the task analysis for buying a DVD